



RESTORATIONESSENTIALS

Factory-Correct Restoration Reference

Jeep CJ-7 (1976–86) Restoration Guide

Model Year 1976–86

Model	Jeep CJ-7 (AMC era), 93.4-in wheelbase
Engines	232/258 I6; 304 V8 (1976–81); GM 151/AMC 150 I4; export diesel
Transfer cases	Dana 20 (1976–79); Dana 300 (1980–86); Quadra-Trac (1976–79)
Production	379,299 built, 1976–86
Notable	Renegade / Golden Eagle / Laredo / 1982 Jamboree (630)

Every specification in this guide was checked against factory literature, marque references, period road tests, and documented survivor cars. Where sources disagree or the record is silent, this guide says so rather than guessing.

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Chapter 1 — The CJ-7: The Long-Wheelbase CJ

The CJ-7 arrived for 1976 as the CJ for people who used doors: a 93.4-inch wheelbase against the CJ-5's 83.5, squared door openings, an available molded hardtop, and — a first for the class — an optional automatic transmission with full-time four-wheel drive. AMC built 379,299 of them over eleven model years. The CJ-7 is simultaneously the most restorable CJ (parts, knowledge, and numbers) and the most modified vehicle in this entire guide series — which makes documentation, not scarcity, the restorer's core skill. This guide works the 1976–86 run as one family with two VIN systems and three drivetrain eras.

Chapter 2 — What Makes the CJ-7 Different

- **Wheelbase and frame:** 93.4 inches, with the frame's rear section stepped outward so springs and dampers sit closer to the wheels — the stability fix the CJ-5 never got.
- **Three eras:** 1976–79 (Dana 20, heavy-duty manuals, Quadra-Trac available), 1980–81 (Dana 300 arrives, SR-4 era, 304's last year), 1982–86 (wide-track axles, five-speed, four-cylinder base).
- **Trim ladder:** Renegade throughout; Golden Eagle to 1980; Laredo from 1980; the 1982 Jamboree as the family's numbered rarity.

Chapter 3 — VIN and Serial Decoding: Two Systems

The 1976–80 cars carry the 13-character Jeep serial: **J** (Jeep), a year digit (6 = 1976 ... 0 = 1980), a transmission letter (A automatic, F 4-speed manual in the documented cars), model digits **93** (CJ-7, 93-inch class), a GVW letter, an engine letter, and the six-digit serial. Documented examples: J6A93EH078115 (a 1976 304 car) and J6F93AA071236 (a 1976 258). Engine letters of the era: A/C for the 258 (1-1/2-barrel), E for the 232, H for the 304 V8.



From 1981 the standardized 17-character VIN applies, with the CJ-7 in the model position (87 in the AMC charts for the 93.4-inch cars) and its own engine-letter table (B = 151 four, C = 258 two-barrel, H = 304 in its last year, U = 150 four later). The decoder charts differ between the two systems — use the chart that matches the plate in front of you, and photograph the plate first.

Chapter 4 — Engines: Sixes, the 304, the Fours, and the Export Diesel

The 258-cubic-inch AMC six is the CJ-7's defining engine — fitted across the whole run, with ratings that wander by year and carburetion (roughly 98–115 hp in the net era). The 232 served as the early base six before the 258 took the role alone. The 304 V8 (1976–81) opens at 150 hp and closes at 125 hp (1980–81; 220 lb-ft) as emissions tuning tightened, with about 130 hp for 1979 — the marque tables print the decline openly, and so does this guide. The four-cylinder cars are real CJ-7s too: GM's 151 'Iron Duke' (1980–83), then AMC's own 150 (1984–86, 105 hp). The Isuzu C240 diesel (1980–82) was export-only, with 4.10 axles — a documented rarity, and the one CJ-7 engine most North American parts counters have never seen.

Chapter 5 — Transmissions by Era

Gearboxes follow the eras of Chapter 2. Early cars: the T-150 three-speed as the base manual, the T-18 four-speed with its granny first gear as the heavy-duty option, and the GM TH400 three-speed automatic behind the Quadra-Trac. The 1980 reorganization brings the SR-4 and T-176 manuals and the Chrysler-built TF999 automatic for sixes and the 304 (TF904 behind the fours). From 1982 the T-4 and T-5 five-speed join. No single gearbox defines a 'correct' CJ-7; the year, engine, and transfer case define the combination, and the marque transmission tables are the arbiter.

Chapter 6 — Transfer Cases: Dana 20, Dana 300, Quadra-Trac

Dana 20 (1976–79) and Dana 300 (1980–86) are the part-time cases; the Dana 300's low range and strength made it the hobby's favorite and it remains in production in aftermarket form. The Borg-Warner 1339 Quadra-Trac (1976–79) is the full-time system paired with the TH400 — and it drives one hard parts rule: Quadra-Trac cars carry an offset-pumpkin AMC 20 rear axle, so driveline swaps on those Jeeps respect the offset or replace the axle deliberately and on paper.

Chapter 7 — Axles: Dana 30, the AMC 20 Question, and Track Widths

The Dana 30 front axle serves the whole run — narrow-track through 1981, wide-track from 1982, a visible and dated change. The rear is the AMC 20, whose two-piece axle shafts are the model's best-documented mechanical weakness; the one-piece shaft conversion is the standard remedy, and on a restored Jeep it is recorded as exactly what it is: a modification that keeps the Jeep alive. A Dana 44 rear appears on a small number of cars (Laredo documentation, 1980) — claimed Dana 44s are verified by the housing, not the listing. Ratios vary by engine and year (3.54 typical early, taller gears later, 4.10 behind the diesel); Trak-Lok limited-slip was the rear option.



Chapter 8 — Trim Packages: Renegade, Golden Eagle, Laredo, Jamboree

Trim on a CJ-7 is graphics, seats, and brightwork — which means it is all reproduced and none of it self-proves. Renegade runs the full eleven years; Golden Eagle (1976–80) is the 304-era flagship; Laredo (1980–86) adds the chrome package, better seats, tilt wheel, and instrument details; Limited appears for 1982–83. The 1982 Jamboree Commemorative Edition — the 30th anniversary of the Jeep Jamboree — is the family's documented rarity: 630 built, 560 in Topaz Gold Metallic and 70 in Olympic White, with a numbered plaque. Verify packages by the trim and paint codes and the Jamboree by its plaque and paper; decals are the last step of a restoration, not evidence at a purchase.

Chapter 9 — Production Numbers and Rarity

CJ-7 figure	Count	Note
All CJ-7s, 1976–86	379,299	11 model years
Jamboree Commemorative (1982)	630	560 gold / 70 white
304 V8 availability	1976–81	after '81: sixes and fours only
Export diesel (C240)	1980–82	export-only program

Rarity inside 379,299 Jeeps is configuration rarity: the Jamboree, the export diesel, early Quadra-Trac 304 cars, and unmodified steel tubs of any year.

Chapter 10 — Rust and Frame Inspection Guide

Two structures, two inspections. The frame: check the steering-box mounting area and front horns for the cracking the 304-era cars made famous, the rear crossmember, and the spring hangers. The tub: floor pans, rocker panels and the hat channels beneath them, cowl and windshield frame, and the rear floor over the tank. The first question on any CJ-7 is whether the tub is steel at all — fiberglass replacement tubs are common and honest when disclosed. Magnet, light, photographs, notes — before negotiation (Chapter 14).

Chapter 11 — Restoration Sequence for the CJ-7

- **1. Document** — VIN/serial plate, engine and transmission/transfer-case identification tags, axle tags, photographs as found.
- **2. Name the Jeep honestly** — year era, engine, trim package, steel or glass tub. The decoder tables and codes decide.
- **3. Frame first** — cracks and rust at the documented points repaired before body money; the tub is judged separately and on its own merits.
- **4. Disassemble by system**; drivetrain combinations recorded as units (engine/transmission/case/axles are an era-matched set or a documented swap).
- **5. Drivetrain to its era's specification**; AMC 20 shaft decision made openly and recorded.
- **6. Paint, decals, and trim-package graphics last**, to the codes — stickers are the receipt, never the evidence.



Chapter 12 — Engine Specifications at a Glance

Engine	Fitted	Rating (net era)
258 I6 (4.2L)	1976–86	~98–115 hp by year
304 V8 (5.0L)	1976–81	150 hp early; 125 hp (1980–81)
232 I6	early years	base six
GM 151 I4 / AMC 150 I4	1980–83 / 1984–86	105 hp (AMC 150)
Isuzu C240 diesel	1980–82 export	4.10 axles, export-only

Chapter 13 — Options and Factory Details

- Quadra-Trac full-time 4WD (1976–79) with TH400 automatic — offset rear axle is part of the package.
- Molded hardtop and full steel doors — the CJ-7's civilizing options.
- Trak-Lok rear limited-slip; axle ratios by engine and year.
- Levi's denim interior package appears in the CJ-7's early years in the period catalogs.
- Renegade/Golden Eagle/Laredo graphics and brightwork per package documentation; Jamboree (1982) numbered plaque.

Chapter 14 — Buyer Inspection Checklist

- Serial/VIN decoded with the correct-era table; engine letter matched to the engine in the bay.
- Tub material established (magnet) — steel or fiberglass priced as what it is.
- Frame at steering box, horns, hangers, and rear crossmember inspected and photographed.
- Transfer case identified (Dana 20 / 300 / Quadra-Trac) and the rear axle's offset checked on Quadra-Trac cars.
- AMC 20 shaft type established; conversions disclosed.
- Trim package verified by codes, Jamboree by plaque and paper.
- Transmission/case combination checked against the era tables (Chapter 5).

Chapter 15 — Casting Numbers, Codes, and Date Codes

AMC engines carry casting numbers and date codes readable against the marque engine references; the VIN's engine letter is the promise they keep or break. Component dating follows the flagship rule — castings precede the vehicle's build and sit close — applied loosely enough for a working 4x4 and strictly enough to catch the wrong engine entirely. Transmission and transfer-case identification tags are photographed before removal, not after.

Chapter 16 — Re-Tubs, Repowers, and Tells That Matter

The CJ-7's modification culture is its charm and its fraud surface. The tells are structural: a fiberglass tub presented as steel, a V8 presented as factory in a four-cylinder VIN, a 'Laredo' that is decals over a base tub, a Dana 300 claimed in a 1978 Jeep. Every one is answered by Chapter 3's decoders and Chapter 14's checklist. The honest version of this hobby names its modifications — one-piece shafts, repowers, re-tubs — in the file, where they add credibility instead of subtracting value.



Chapter 17 — Critical Fasteners: Sequence and Sources

No torque value is printed that cannot be traced to factory service literature. The discipline stands: clean chased threads, lubrication as the manual specifies, the printed pattern in at least three steps, re-checks after the first heat cycle where called for — and factory values for steering-box, spring-hanger, and body-mount hardware, which on a CJ are the structure itself. Values come from the Jeep service literature in Sources; record what you used.

Recommended for this restoration

Shop exact-fit supplies on Amazon

- Jeep CJ-7 factory service manual 1976-1986
- AMC 258 inline six engine rebuild kit
- Jeep CJ restoration parts
- Jeep CJ-7 parts catalog

As an Amazon Associate, RestorationEssentials earns from qualifying purchases made through these links.

Sources Consulted

Every specification in this guide was checked against published references before printing. Where sources disagree, this guide says so in the text rather than picking a number silently. The references below are the backbone of the technical chapters:

- **Jeep factory literature.** the Jeep service manuals and dealer ordering information for 1976–86 — authority for torque values, specifications, and option definitions
- **Jeep marque technical references (jeeptech.com).** CJ-7 engine, transmission, transfer-case, and axle fitments by year
- **Published CJ VIN-decoding systems.** the 1975–80 serial system and the 1981–86 17-character system with engine-letter tables
- **Hagerty valuation listings.** documented CJ-7 VINs, engine ratings, and generation data (1976–86)
- **CJ-7 production reporting.** the 379,299 total and package histories, including the 1982 Jamboree Commemorative Edition

A note on numbers. Factory literature, period road tests, and marque historians do not always agree — production totals, horsepower ratings, and paint codes all have documented conflicts. This guide uses the best-supported figure in each case and flags the conflict where one exists, so you can judge for yourself.



Thank You

Thank you for choosing this RestorationEssentials guide. Whether this is your first Jeep CJ-7 (1976–86) or your fiftieth, you picked one of the great ones, and the fact that you are doing your homework before you turn a wrench puts you ahead of most of the field.

These cars survived because people like you refused to let them disappear. Every correct fastener, every properly decoded tag, every hour spent getting the details right keeps the history honest for the next owner and the next generation of enthusiasts.

The CJ that civilized the breed — doors, a hardtop, and 379,299 chances to get it right. Restore yours by its codes, name its modifications honestly, and drive it like they built it to be driven.

If this guide helped your build, we would love to hear about it. Good luck with the restoration, and enjoy every mile.

— The RestorationEssentials Team